TSHIAMO'S HOPE FOUNDATION

NICU DISCHARGE PLANNING CHECKLIST

From the NICU to home, one step at a time

Going home is a milestone worth celebrating — and it's completely normal to feel both relief and anxiety about leaving the NICU "bubble." Every baby's discharge criteria are set by their own care team, so use this checklist as a general guide alongside their advice, not a replacement for it.

MEDICAL MILESTONES BEFORE DISCHARGE

	Maintains stable temperature in an open cot		Car seat / car bed test passed
	Passed hearing screening		Taking all feeds by breast or bottle, or a home tube-feeding plan is in place
	Breathing steadily without desaturations		Immunisations up to date for age
	Passed eye examination (ROP screening)		Steady weight gain over several consecutive days
	Off oxygen, or stable on home oxygen plan		Newborn screening tests completed

EDUCATION & TRAINING FOR PARENTS

	Infant CPR / resuscitation training completed		Trained on home oxygen or apnea monitor (if applicable)
	Safe sleep practices discussed		Signs of illness & when to seek help explained
	Trained on tube feeding (if applicable)		Medication dosing, timing & side effects explained
	Kangaroo care / bonding techniques reviewed		Feeding cues and techniques reviewed

HOME READINESS

	Car seat installed and tested		Preemie-sized clothing & nappies stocked
	Emergency contact list posted at home		Smoke detectors working
	Crib / bassinet set up (safe sleep guidelines)		Home medical equipment delivered & set up
	Room temperature suitable for baby		Support person arranged for the first week home

DOCUMENTATION & FOLLOW-UP

	Discharge summary received from the NICU		Follow-up paediatrician appointment scheduled
	Immunisation schedule / road-to-health card updated		Medical aid / insurance claims submitted
	Prescriptions collected		Specialist follow-ups scheduled (cardiology, eyes, hearing, etc.)
	Home visit / community nurse arranged (if applicable)		Birth certificate / clinic card in order

EMOTIONAL READINESS

	Talked through feelings about leaving the NICU with staff or a counsellor		Know who to call for emotional support after discharge
	Know who to call for medical support after discharge		Realistic expectations set for the adjustment period at home
	Support system informed of the discharge date		

Every box ticked is one step closer to home. You've got this. With love and hope, Tshiamo's Hope Foundation